

CHAPTER 13: BUILDING DESIGN STANDARDS

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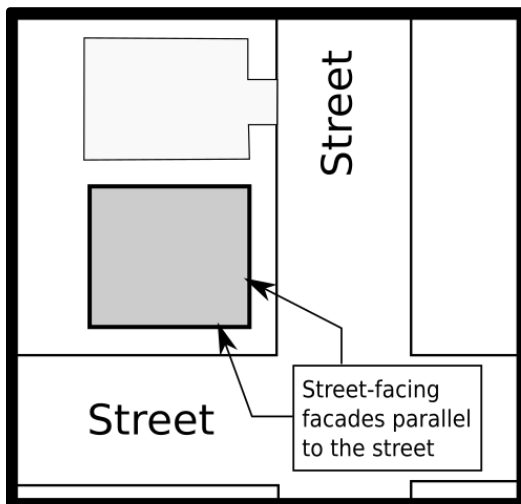
CHAPTER 13: BUILDING DESIGN STANDARDS

Section 13.1 Purpose and Applicability

The purpose of this chapter is to ensure architectural compatibility and the establishment and preservation of architectural character throughout the Town. Enumerated in the sections below are general requirements for all buildings as well as requirements specific to building use and typology. All new construction shall conform to the architectural requirements of this chapter.

Section 13.2 General Requirements for All Buildings

- A. Adjacent buildings shall be compatible in regard to spacing, setbacks, proportions, materials*, and scale. Requirements for materials and proportions shall not apply to single- and two-family residential buildings, except as described in Section 13.3 below.
- B. The primary entrance shall be architecturally and functionally designed on the front façade facing the primary public street. This requirement may be waived by the Planning Board in cases where a planned development consists of buildings lining the public street but are internally oriented, with entrances on both the interior facing façade and the primary street facing façade.
- C. The front façade of the principal structure shall be parallel to the front lot line and street. For lots with multiple street frontages, the street-facing facades of the principal structure shall be parallel to the street. For multiple street frontage lots with streets that do not meet at right angles, the Zoning Administrator may adjust how the street-facing façade addresses the street.



- D. Ground mounted mechanical equipment shall be located to the rear or side yard and screened from view of the street. Roof-mounted mechanical equipment shall be screened from view by a parapet wall matching the primary building materials.
- E. Fences shall be constructed with the finished side facing the adjacent property or street.

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Section 13.3 Residential Buildings

13.3.1 Single-Family Detached Two-Family (Duplex) Residential Buildings, or Townhouses Built to Single Family Building Code*

- A. Exterior materials should be durable and residential in character. Exterior wall materials should be wood clapboard siding, wood shingles, brick, stone, stucco, vinyl, or similar materials. Roof materials should be asphalt shingles, standing seam metal, slate, or similar materials.
- B. Pitched roofs should have a pitch between 4:12 and 12:12. Eaves shall be a minimum of nine (9) inches in depth.
- C. Garages should not have visual prominence on the front façade. Garages that face the street should be recessed from the front façade as follows:
 - If the structure has a usable front porch that is at least six (6) feet deep and extends more than 50 percent of the front façade, then the garage may be flush with the front façade.
 - If the structure **does not have** a usable front porch that is at least six (6) feet deep and extends more than 50 percent of the front façade, then the garage should be recessed from the front façade a minimum of four (4) feet.
- D. Attached garages for more than two (2) cars should not face the primary street. Such garages on corner lots may face the non-fronting street.
- E. Wherever possible, two-family (duplex) residences should be designed in such a way that the primary entrances are not both on the same plane of the front façade. Two-family residences are preferred on corner lots with one unit's primary entrance facing one fronting street and the other units facing the other fronting street.

*Per NCGS 160D-702(b), the standards of Section 13.3.1 are recommendations for voluntary conditions attached to Conditional Zoning district requests.

13.3.2 Multi-family Residential Buildings and Townhouses not built to single family building code

- A. Exterior materials shall be durable and residential in character. Suggested materials include wood clapboard siding, wood shingles, brick, stone, stucco, vinyl, or similar materials. Suggested pitched roof materials include asphalt shingles, standing seam metal, slate, or similar materials.
- B. Garage doors are not permitted on the front façade of any multi-family dwelling unit or townhouse not built to single family building code.
- C. Adjacent Townhouse units shall be recessed or otherwise articulated from each other in order to avoid a monolithic appearance.

13.3.3 Manufactured Homes

A manufactured home must bear a seal certifying that it meets or exceeds the construction standards promulgated by the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development that were in effect at the time of construction and that satisfies each of the following additional criteria:

- A. Manufactured homes that are on individual lots not within a Manufactured Home Park shall be multi-sectional. Single-wide manufactured homes shall not be permitted on individual lots.

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- B. The exterior siding shall consist of wood, hardboard, vinyl, brick, or similar material and shall be comparable in composition, appearance, and durability to the exterior siding commonly used in standard residential construction.
- C. A continuous masonry curtain wall foundation shall be installed under the perimeter, unpierced except for required ventilation and access. Exposed standard concrete block is not permitted.
- D. The tongue, axles, transporting lights, and removable towing apparatus are removed after placement on the lot and before occupancy.
- E. A permanent front porch of at least 32 square feet in area shall be constructed within six (6) inches of the floor elevation and be fully underpinned to completely conceal the area beneath the porch and unit. All secondary entrances and exits to the mobile home shall also have concrete steps or similar approved steps.

Section 13.4 Commercial and Mixed Use Buildings

13.4.1 Commercial and Mixed Use Buildings

13.4.1.1 Materials & Color

- A. Exterior walls visible from the public street shall be at least 75 percent brick, split-face concrete block, stucco, stone, or other materials similar in appearance and durability.
- B. Vinyl siding, standard concrete block, cast concrete, metal may be used on building walls not visible from a public street or as minority elements or accent materials on walls that are visible from the public street provided that they do not compose greater than 25 percent of the façade.
- C. Brick, stone or decorative masonry units shall not be painted unless approved by the Technical Review Committee or Planning Board
- D. Two wall materials may be combined horizontally on one façade. The heavier material should be below.
- E. Pitched roofs should be clad in standing seam metal, slate, asphalt shingles or similar material. Long span metal panels may be used on pitched roofs that are not visible from the street.
- F. Facade colors shall be of low reflectance earth tone, muted, subtle, or neutral colors. Building trim may feature brighter colors. The use of high-intensity or metallic colors is not allowed except for accent purposes. Fluorescent or neon colors shall be prohibited as a primary wall color. Variations in color schemes are encouraged in order to articulate entryways and public amenities so as to give greater recognition to these features.
- G. Accessory structures consisting of residential type sheds are not permitted as accessory structures for commercial or mixed use buildings. Accessory structures for commercial or mixed use buildings shall be designed and have building materials that are compatible with the primary structure.

13.4.1.2 Configuration

- A. Roof pitches less than 3:12 and flat roofs shall require a parapet wall on all sides visible from the street. Parapet walls shall fully screen all roof-top mechanical equipment from the street.
- B. A pitched roof shall have eaves a minimum of 12 inches from the building face.
- C. Parapet walls shall have decorative cornices or caps.
- D. At least 50 percent of the length of the first floor on primary street fronting facades shall be in windows or doorways. Street level windows and doors for new construction shall be 60% clear glazed to provide an unobstructed transparent view. Existing buildings shall provide 60% clear

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glazed for existing first-floor windows of the primary fronting façade. Mirrorized or tinted glass obstructing the transparent view is not permitted in any location. Faux or display casements are not permitted in lieu of exterior window treatments for the frontage elevation.

A window shall be measured as follows:

- Maximum Sill Height (first floor): 42 inches
 - Minimum Area: 16 square feet
 - Minimum Width: 3 feet
 - Minimum Height: 4 feet
- E. All buildings of two or more stories shall have street-facing facades which are at least 25% transparent for floors two and above. Such transparency shall be achieved through the use of visually permeable windows or doors.
- F. For buildings on a corner, the first floor secondary street façade shall be at least 10 percent visually permeable windows. A window or functional general access doorway shall be located along the length of the facade at least every 20 feet. Faux or display casements may be considered by the Technical Review Committee or Planning Board.
- G. Ventilation grates or emergency exit doors located at the first-floor level oriented toward a public street shall be decorative.
- H. Residential uses in mixed use buildings shall not be located on the street level.
- I. When used, awnings and canopies shall be placed at the top of window or doorway openings. No awning shall extend more than the width of the sidewalk or 10 feet, whichever is less. Awnings must be self-supporting from the wall. No supports shall rest on or interfere with the use of pedestrian walkways or streets. In no case shall any awning extend beyond the street curb or interfere with street trees or public utilities.
- J. Canopies shall be of solid material and complement the color of the building to which they are affixed or associated. Gas station canopies shall be located in the side or rear yard only and must be set back from the property and right-of-way lines a minimum of the required setback of accessory buildings, as required in the zoning district where located, and must not interfere with street trees or public utilities.
- K. Dumpsters must be placed behind the midpoint of the sideyard in relation to the front line of the building and screened as required in Chapter 11.

13.4.1.3 Additional Standards for Development in the C-B District

A. Purpose

The objective of this section is to ensure new development in the C-B District demonstrates an urban form and compatibility with the traditional development pattern of Downtown China Grove. Key development features include building placement on the street; the use of building materials consistent or compatible with those typically found in buildings Downtown; building design which is compatible in scale and form with surrounding buildings; and transparent building elements, such as 60% clear glazed doors and windows, to allow visual interaction between building occupants and pedestrians.

B. Applicability

The standards of Section 13.4.1.3 shall apply to new construction and additions only (additions shall not create a greater degree of nonconformity with the regulations of this section than what

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currently exists on-site). Provisions for redeveloping older sites in the C-B District are detailed in Section 5.9.

C. Building Build-To/Setbacks

Street frontage of C-B zoned parcels shall be occupied by buildings with build-to lines of 0-5'.

D. Building Entrances

Buildings in the C-B District shall include one street-level building entrance for every 100' of building frontage.

E. Screening of Parking Areas

Parking areas within 40' of any rights-of-way shall be screened by a fence or wall of at least 30 inches in height. Said fence or wall shall be compatible with the materials and design of adjacent structures.

F. Alternative Compliance

Development in the C-B District unable to meet the standards of Section 13.4.1.3 may be approved by Town Council through the Conditional Zoning process, where Council determines such development meets or exceeds the intent of these standards.

13.4.1.4 Additional Standards for Development in the N-C and H-B District

A. Applicability

The standards of Section 13.4.1.4 shall apply to new construction and additions only (additions shall not create a greater degree of nonconformity with the regulations of this section than what currently exists on-site). Provisions for redeveloping older sites in the N-C and H-B District are detailed in Section 5.9.

B. Building Entrances

Buildings in the N-C and H-B District shall have at least one primary entrance facing the street.

C. Building Placement

A minimum of 40% of the street frontage of N-C zoned parcels shall be occupied by buildings with build-to-lines of between 0-25'. A minimum of 25% of the street frontage of H-B zoned parcels shall be occupied by buildings with build-to-lines of between 0-25'.

D. Façade Articulation

Street-facing building facades greater than 75' in length shall incorporate recesses and projections of at least 3' along at least 20% of the façade's length.

E. Multiple Uses Required

Developments over 20,000 square feet in size shall contain two or more uses. Such uses may exist in the same building, or may exist within different buildings on-site.

F. Parking Reduction for Developments with Two or More Uses

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Minimum parking requirements for developments containing two or more uses (including two or more different uses of the same use classification) shall be reduced by 30%.

G. Parking Maximums

Parking in excess of 175% of minimum UDO parking requirements for a site shall only be approved by Town Council through the Conditional Zoning process.

H. Alternative Compliance

Development in the N-C and H-B Districts unable to meet the standards of Section 13.8 may be approved by Town Council through the Conditional Zoning process, where Council determines such development meets or exceeds the intent of these standards.

Section 13.5 Civic Buildings

Civic buildings should create visual anchors for the community and shall adhere to the following:

- A. Civic building walls shall primarily be clad in stone, stucco, brick, or marble. Decorative cast concrete, concrete block, metal, wood, or vinyl siding may be used as a minority element (maximum of 25 percent) on facades visible from the street.
- B. Pitched roofs should be clad in standing seam metal, slate, asphalt shingles or similar material. Long span metal panels may be used on pitched roofs that are not visible from the street.

Section 13.6 Industrial Buildings

- A. Front facades of industrial buildings shall be primarily brick, stucco, stone, decorative concrete block or other materials similar in appearance and durability. Standard concrete block, cast concrete, and metal may be used as minority elements (maximum of 50 percent) on the front facade. All accessory buildings shall be clad in materials similar in appearance to the principal structure.
- B. Pitched roofs shall be clad in standing seam metal, long span metal panels, slate, asphalt shingles or similar material.
- C. Flat roofs shall incorporate parapet walls to conceal the flat portions of the roof elevations that are visible from any public street. Parapet walls shall screen roof-top mechanical equipment from the street.

Section 13.7 Alternative Methods of Compliance

13.7.1 Use of Alternate Plan, Material, or Methods

Alternate design plans, building materials or construction techniques may be used when unreasonable or impractical situations would result from the application of architectural design standards. Such situations may result from unique site conditions, innovative design applications, and/or unified development design.

13.7.2 Evaluation by Technical Review Committee

The performance of alternate design standards shall be evaluated by the TRC to determine if the alternate design meets the intent and purpose of this ordinance. This determination shall take into account the land

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use of adjacent property, the orientation of the building to streets, the building typology, the intended use of the structure, attention to architectural detail, scale and mass.

13.7.3 Appeal

Decisions of the TRC regarding alternate methods of compliance may be appealed to the Board of Adjustment in accordance with Chapter 16.